that an Indian patrol had entered Galwan on 6 July and had ‘attempted to cut off’ an established Chinese post in the lower reaches of the valley.

Even as India refuted the Chinese claim and pointed to the existence of Galwan FDL, on 10 July at 9.30 a.m. a party of twenty-five Chinese soldiers deployed 180 metres from the Indian post. Within the hour, fifty more men had joined the initial group and cut off the track to the helipad. By nightfall, 300 more Chinese soldiers had joined their comrades who not only encircled the Gorkhas, but occupied positions sixty-five metres from the post.

With the Chinese all around them, the Gorkhas continued to hold their ground. Commanded by Naib Subedar Jang Bahadur Gurung, the Indian post held its fire through those nerve-racking hours. In the next few days, the Chinese deployed two of their companies to the north and northwest of Galwan FDL, their forward position being around 180 metres from the Indian post’s defences. Another company was deployed even closer, at about 90 metres, to the east and southeast of Galwan FDL. On the diplomatic front, Peking kept up the shrill rhetoric, claiming through protest notes that Indian troops had opened fire on 19 July, 16 August, 2 September and then again on 3 October.

By mid-July, Captain Kotwal’s reconnaissance teams sent out from Patrol Base had reported that it was almost impossible to reinforce Galwan FDL by the land route. The only way then for 5 Jat, earmarked to replace the Gorkhas at Galwan FDL, to move into the Galwan Sector was by helicopter. Twenty-five men from 5 Jat’s Alpha Company under Major S. S. Hasabnis were finally inducted into Galwan FDL by IAF helicopters that started landing at Helipad from 4 October. The Gorkhas, having lived cheek by jowl with the Chinese for more than two months, were ferried out by returning Mi-4 helicopters over the next four days.

THE BATTLE FOR GALWAN

On the morning of 20 October, Galwan FDL under the command of Major Hasabnis and Subedar Hoshiar Singh was being held by two sections of 5 Jats’ Alpha Company. A section was deployed at each of the two OPs, while Ration Party was being held by a platoon. Helipad had a handful of men, while the Galwan-Shyok river junction was the responsibility of Subedar Balraj Singh who had two sections of 14 J&K Militia under his command. Though the IAF helicopters were keeping the lines of communication open,